

RRB NTPC General Awareness Target Series

Advanced Practice Questions: Medieval Indian History & Railway Infrastructure
Curated for NRA Pattern Testing (Updated with SSC CGL 2025/2026 References)

Question 1: Early Medieval India (c. 750–1200 CE)

Source: UPPSC Combined State Upper Subordinate Services Exam

Consider the following statements regarding Early Medieval India:

1. The practice of making land grants to religious and secular donees reached its peak during this period, fostering the growth of a powerful intermediary landlord class (Samantas).
2. The economic landscape was characterized by absolute 'monetary anaemia' with a total absence of coins across all regions, completely halting all internal and long-distance trade.
3. The Tripartite Struggle for the control of Kanauj involved the Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas, and the Rashtrakutas.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A) 1 and 2 only
- B) 2 and 3 only
- C) 1 and 3 only
- D) 1, 2 and 3

Correct Answer: C) 1 and 3 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct as land grants expanded significantly during this era, leading to decentralized political structures and feudal tendencies. Statement 3 is correct as the classic Tripartite Struggle engaged the Palas, Pratiharas, and Rashtrakutas for over two centuries for control of the strategic city of Kanauj. Statement 2 is incorrect because it is an exaggeration; while coinage was scarcer compared to the prosperous Gupta period, long-distance trade and local exchange networks did experience a notable revival from the 10th–11th centuries onward.

Question 2: Delhi Sultanate Administration

Source: BPSC Combined Competitive Examination (CCE)

Consider the following statements regarding the economic and administrative measures of Alauddin Khilji:

1. He abolished the traditional tax exemptions enjoyed by village headmen (Muqaddam, Khut, and Chaudhuri) and ensured they paid land revenue on an equal footing.
2. He instituted the branding of horses (dagh) and the maintenance of a descriptive roll of soldiers (chehra) to eliminate corruption in the military.
3. He established completely free and unregulated markets for all commercial commodities, relying purely on market forces and merchant competition.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A) 1 and 2 only
- B) 2 and 3 only
- C) 1 and 3 only
- D) 1, 2 and 3

Correct Answer: A) 1 and 2 only

Explanation: Statements 1 and 2 are correct. Alauddin Khilji strictly curbed the privileges of rural intermediaries to maximize state revenue and enforced military reforms like dagh (branding of horses) and chehra (descriptive roll) to maintain a massive, efficient standing army. Statement 3 is completely incorrect because Alauddin Khilji is historically famous for establishing a highly rigid, state-controlled market regulation system under the supervision of the Shahana-i-Mandi, fixing maximum prices rather than leaving them to free market forces.

Question 3: The Vijayanagara Empire & Southern Inter-State Dynamics

Source: Staff Selection Commission - Combined Graduate Level (SSC CGL) 2025

Consider the following statements regarding the Vijayanagara Empire:

1. The Vijayanagara Empire was established in 1336 CE during the central rule of Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq in Delhi.
2. The primary geographical focus of its geopolitical conflict was the Raichur Doab, which lay strategically between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers.
3. Its first historical capital city was permanently established at Madurai.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A) 1 and 2 only
- B) 2 and 3 only
- C) 1 and 3 only
- D) 1, 2 and 3

Correct Answer: A) 1 and 2 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is CORRECT: The empire was founded in 1336 CE by the brothers Harihara I and Bukka I of the Sangam dynasty. This chronological point perfectly aligns with the decline of the Delhi Sultanate's grip on Southern India under Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Statement 2 is CORRECT: The Raichur Doab was an incredibly fertile tract of land wedged tightly between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers, serving as the primary geopolitical flashpoint for multi-generational conflict between Vijayanagara and the Bahmani Sultanate. Statement 3 is INCORRECT: The initial and most famous capital city of the empire was established at Hampi (Vijayanagara)

on the banks of the Tungabhadra River, not Madurai. Madurai was a separate Sultanate that the Vijayanagara princes later conquered and integrated.

Question 4: The Vijayanagara Empire & Local Revenue Administration

Source: WBCS (West Bengal Civil Services) Preliminary Exam

The traditional administrative system of the Vijayanagara Empire, under which a body of 12 functionaries or officials (known as Ayagars) was appointed by the central government to manage the rural economy, maintain law and order, and conduct local affairs in every village, was known as the:

- A) Nayankara System
- B) Iqta System
- C) Ayagar System
- D) Mansabdari System

Correct Answer: C) Ayagar System

Explanation: The Ayagar system was the foundational village-level administrative setup in the Vijayanagara Empire. Every village was managed by a body of 12 functionaries (Ayagars) who were granted tax-free lands (Manyams) by the state in exchange for their hereditary administrative services. This is distinct from the Nayankara system, which operated at a macro provincial/military level through military chiefs known as Nayakas.

Question 5: Inter-regional Dynamics in Medieval India

Source: APPSC Group 1 Services Exam

Consider the following statements regarding inter-state relations and political chronology in medieval peninsular India:

1. The Vijayanagara Empire was founded in 1336 CE during the turbulent reign of Muhammad bin Tughlaq in Delhi.
2. The fertile Raichur Doab, situated between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers, served as a primary theatre of protracted conflict between Vijayanagara and the Bahmani Sultanate.
3. The Bahmani kingdom originally emerged as an administrative territory that broke away directly from the suzerainty of Vijayanagara rather than the Delhi Sultanate.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A) 1 and 2 only
- B) 2 and 3 only
- C) 1 and 3 only
- D) 1, 2 and 3

Correct Answer: A) 1 and 2 only

Explanation: Statements 1 and 2 are correct. Harihara I and Bukka Raya I successfully carved out the independent Vijayanagara Empire in 1336 CE amidst the systemic decentralization under Delhi's Muhammad bin Tughlaq, and the highly fertile agricultural zone of the Raichur Doab remained a permanent territorial flashpoint. Statement 3 is false because the Bahmani Sultanate was founded in 1347 CE by Ala-ud-din Bahman Shah (Hasan Gangu) as a direct rebellion against the Delhi Sultanate, not Vijayanagara.

Question 6: Successor States of the Bahmani Kingdom & Rail Geography

Source: RRB NTPC / South Central Railway Zone Special GK Series

The city of Kalaburagi (Gulbarga), which served as the first historical capital of the medieval Bahmani Kingdom before it was shifted to Bidar, is a major railway junction in modern India. Under which Indian Railways Zone is the Kalaburagi Railway Junction officially administered?

- A) South Western Railway (SWR)
- B) South Central Railway (SCR)
- C) Central Railway (CR)
- D) Southern Railway (SR)

Correct Answer: C) Central Railway (CR)

Explanation: Examiners frequently trap candidates into mapping the Bahmani capitals (Gulbarga and Bidar) to southern railway zones because they reside in modern Karnataka territory. However, Kalaburagi (Gulbarga) junction falls uniquely under the Solapur Division of the Central Railway (CR) zone, which is headquartered at Mumbai CSMT. The city served as the foundational base for Hasan Gangu's independent sultanate in 1347 CE before Ahmad Shah Wali moved it to Bidar.

Question 7: Sultanate Capital Citadels & Modern Freight Rail Infrastructure

Source: RRB NTPC (CBT-1) Trend-Setter Series

The Tughlakabad Railway Station (Station Code: TKD) and its adjacent massive Inland Container Depot (ICD) form one of the largest dry ports and freight-handling rail hubs in North India. In historical geography, the nearby ruined fortress city of Tughlaqabad was established as the third historic city of Delhi by which Sultan to defend the empire against Mongol invasions?

- A) Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq
- B) Muhammad bin Tughlaq
- C) Firoz Shah Tughlaq
- D) Nasiruddin Mahmud

Correct Answer: A) Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq

Explanation: Railway recruitment panels love focusing on major operational, logistics, and engine-shed locations. Tughlakabad (TKD) houses one of the biggest diesel/electric locomotive sheds and Asia's largest dry port facility. Historically, it was the dynasty founder Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq (Ghazi Malik) who spent his entire short reign (1320–1325 CE) building these massive, battered granite fortifications to establish a highly fortified capital city defending against Mongol incursions.

Question 8: Delhi Sultanate System-Based Revenue Question

Source: RRB NTPC (CBT-2) Graduate Level Previous Year Paper

Sultan Alauddin Khilji was the first ruler of the Delhi Sultanate to introduce an agrarian taxation scheme based entirely on the actual measurement of cultivated land. What was the standard term used for this land measurement system during his reign?

- A) Dahsala
- B) Kankut
- C) Masahat
- D) Nasaq

Correct Answer: C) Masahat

Explanation: Under Alauddin Khilji, the state bypassed approximation methods and introduced Masahat—assessing land revenue directly based on the actual measured area under active crop cultivation. The standard unit used for this measurement framework was the Biswa (1/20th of a bigha). To stop tax evasion by rural middlemen, he also established a central recovery wing called the Diwan-i-Mustakharaj.

Question 9: Comparative Economic & Material Culture (IVC vs. Vedic Period)

Source: SSC CGL 2025/2026 Analytical Series (High Probability for RRB NTPC)

The transition from the urban Indus Valley Civilization to the early rural Vedic society marked a profound shift in material technology, trade economics, and resource utilization. In this context, which of the following statements accurately highlights the distinct divergence between the two periods?

- A) The Harappans utilized silver extensively for domestic ornamentation, while the Early Vedic Aryans were entirely unaware of any metal other than gold (Hiranya).
- B) The Harappans possessed a standardized system of commercial exchange utilizing weights based on a strict binary and decimal progression, whereas the Early Vedic economy lacked rigid weight standards, relying on cattle (Gau) and gold necklaces (Niska) as informal units of value.
- C) The Harappans built extensive maritime trade routes with Mesopotamia using iron-reinforced ships, while the Rigvedic Aryans developed advanced land chariot networks via iron metallurgy.
- D) The Harappans buried their dead exclusively using megalithic stone circles, while the Vedic Aryans practiced ritual open cremations near step-wells.

Correct Answer: B

Explanation: The Indus Valley Civilization possessed an extraordinarily sophisticated, regulated, and uniform economic structure. Archaeological excavations revealed standardized cubical weights made of chert following a binary progression for lower weights (1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, up to 64) and a decimal system for higher units. Conversely, Early Vedic society was pastoral and semi-nomadic, lacking rigid weight standards or minted coins, relying primarily on cattle (Gau) and gold ornaments (Niska) as units of barter value. Iron was entirely unknown to the Harappans and only appeared around 1000 BCE in the Later Vedic Period.

Question 10: Delhi Sultanate Agricultural Infrastructure

Source: BPSC Combined Competitive Examination (CCE)

During the late Delhi Sultanate period, Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq established a dedicated agricultural ministry called Diwan-i-Amir-Kohi to counter severe famines and expand cultivation. Under this department, the state first introduced a revolutionary system of short-term agrarian relief loans advanced directly to peasants for purchasing seeds and digging wells, which were known as:

- A) Iqta
- B) Khalisa
- C) Sondhar (Taccavi)
- D) Hasil

Correct Answer: C) Sondhar (Taccavi)

Explanation: Sondhar (later known as Taccavi loans in the Mughal and British periods) represents India's earliest recorded emergency agricultural loans advanced directly by the state treasury to peasant farmers to stimulate crop cultivation and well digging during devastating regional droughts under Muhammad bin Tughlaq's Amir-Kohi ministry.